

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE · CONFIDENTIAL — FOR FAMILY
REVIEW



The Architecture of Grace

BOOK THREE · THE INTERIOR

Home Edition

FOR FAMILIES · GRADES 6-8

The complete year-long curriculum — every lesson,
undiluted — re-engineered for delivery by a parent at
home, one conversation at a time.

FREE PREVIEW

This free preview includes the parent's opening letter, how to use the book, the
crisis & safety quick-reference, and the first complete lesson — read it end to end.
The full 4 units · 28 lessons are available in the Store.

Before You Begin

A letter to the parent of a child in grades 3, 4, or 5

This book hands you the entire Architecture of Grace · Interior curriculum — the grades 6–8 year — **nothing simplified, nothing left out**. What changes is the delivery. In school a teacher runs these lessons with a class, journals, and anchor charts. Here, you are the guide — though at this age your role shifts from teacher to something more like a trusted consultant. The work happens in real conversation, on your teen's terms.

Middle school is where the Mask hardens. Your child is now sophisticated enough to perform a different self for every audience — and exhausted enough by it to lose track of who's underneath. For autistic teens this is doubled: years of masking to “pass” can leave them genuinely unsure which is the Mask and which is the Mirror. This year is about the gap between the two, and the cost of keeping it wide. The spine is still **guilt** (I did something — fixable) versus **shame** (I am wrong — a lie).

WHAT WE NEED TO TELL YOU — DIRECTLY

Early adolescence is the steepest risk window of childhood, and autistic teens are at markedly elevated risk for self-harm and suicidal thoughts — driven by bullying that peaks in these years, the accumulating exhaustion of masking, autistic burnout, and rejection sensitivity. It can show as withdrawal, irritability, a collapsing digital life, or a flat “whatever.” If your teen signals — in words, writing, or behavior — that they don't want to be here, take it seriously the first time. Don't argue. Don't debate it. Get help.

A few things this book asks of you:

- ◆ **Respect the growing need for autonomy.** Teens pull away — that's development, not rejection. Consult; don't lecture. A lesson offered sideways lands; a lesson delivered head-on bounces.
- ◆ **The after-school shutdown is bigger now.** Years of masking accumulate. Autistic burnout — a deep, lasting depletion — is a real risk in these years. The kid who can barely speak at 4 p.m. isn't being moody; they're spent.
- ◆ **Don't force eye contact, sharing, or "opening up" on a schedule.** Side-by-side, low-demand, their timing. A car ride or a shared screen beats a face-to-face "let's talk."
- ◆ **Their digital life is real life.** It's where both connection and cruelty live. Treat it seriously, not dismissively — and for many autistic teens, online community is a genuine lifeline, not an escape.
- ◆ **When a lesson is bigger than you — say so.** "This one's hard. Let's loop in your counselor." That isn't failing. It models exactly what this curriculum teaches.

ONE MORE THING

You are not failing if your teen rolls their eyes, shuts the door, or says "this is dumb." Seeds planted now germinate later, often invisibly. You are still the steadiest thing in their life. You are reading this. You are trying. That is the work.

ORIENTATION

How to Use This Book

A flip book — one complete lesson per spread, in any order you like

There are **28 lessons**, grouped into 4 units, mirroring the school year. You do not have to do them in order. Open to a lesson, read it once, and let it surface over the week — in the car, over a snack, walking the dog, side by side on the couch. At this age, the indirect moment beats the scheduled "talk" almost every time.

Every lesson is built from the same six parts — once you know the shape of one, you know all 28:

① CORE DIRECT INSTRUCTION — HOME DELIVERY

The actual school lesson — objective, concepts, and steps intact — rewritten for one child and one adult at home, in real conversation rather than a scheduled block.

② THE AUTISM LENS

Three fixed supports: Make It Literal & Concrete, Sensory Regulation (matched to the lesson's emotional load), and Universal Design for Communication — so the lesson works whether your child speaks, types, uses AAC, points, or draws.

③ ELITE CONVERSATION STARTERS

Low-pressure, one-question prompts tagged to the natural moments of a day — each paired with a script to model on yourself first.

④ PRINTABLE VISUAL ASSETS & CHARTS

Ready-to-print anchor charts and home tools — fridge-and-binder versions of the classroom's visuals.

▲ SAFETY & ESCALATION

On every lesson: a clear line for when to bring in a professional. On high-stakes lessons this band grows — and tells you plainly when a conversation belongs to your child's counselor, not to you alone.

◆ PARENT REFLECTION

One private question after each lesson. Not homework. A place to put what the lesson stirred up — because it will.

IF YOU ONLY HAVE THREE MINUTES

Read the Crisis & Safety page next. Then read Lesson 1 (The Mask vs. The Mirror) and Lesson 2 (The Anatomy of a Mistake — shame vs. guilt). Those three pages are the foundation of everything else.

QUICK REFERENCE · KEEP THIS PAGE VISIBLE

If You Need Help Right Now

Crisis & safety numbers — fill in the local line before you ever need it

988	Suicide & Crisis Lifeline — call or text · 24/7 · free
741741	Crisis Text Line — text HOME · for when speaking isn't possible
911	Immediate danger. If you can, ask for a CIT-trained officer and say your child is autistic.
—	Your local mobile crisis line — write it here now: _____

A NOTE ON CALLING 911

Police interactions can be dangerous for autistic people if officers are not trained. When possible, call mobile crisis, your pediatrician, or 988 first. Reserve 911 for immediate physical danger.

FOR THE PARENT OF AN AUTISTIC CHILD

In the 3–5 years, distress often shows as withdrawal, shutdown, somatic complaints, or a sudden change — not the words “I feel sad.” Watch the whole child. When in doubt, ask your pediatrician or counselor. You are never overreacting by checking.

UNIT ONE



Identity & the Weight of Perception

Before a teen can be kind to anyone else, they need an honest sense of who they are underneath the performance. Unit 1 names the Mask and the Mirror, separates shame from guilt, examines digital identity and peer pressure, and ends by claiming authorship of their own story rather than the labels others assign.

SEPTEMBER – OCTOBER · SEVEN LESSONS

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1 · HOME EDITION

The Mask vs. The Mirror

STANDARD

The persona you perform vs. who you actually are — and the gap between them

OBJECTIVE

Your teen can distinguish the social Mask they perform from the authentic Mirror underneath, and name at least two gaps between them.

CASEL FOCUS

Self-Awareness — accurate self-perception & identity formation

VOCABULARY

mask · mirror · persona · authentic · the gap

AT HOME

35–40 min · September · The first lesson of the year

① Core Direct Instruction — Home Delivery

1

OPEN THE QUESTION · 4 MIN “Think about the last time you walked into a social situation and consciously managed how you were coming across. What were you managing? What were you hiding?” Let it land — no answer required out loud.

- 2 **NAME THE MASK · 6 MIN** “Everyone wears a Mask — a social performance. It’s not always dishonest; often it’s just sensible. The problem is when it becomes so automatic we lose contact with what’s underneath.” What goes in the Mask column — what we show, perform, hide, emphasize?
- 3 **NAME THE MIRROR · 6 MIN** “The Mirror is what’s actually there when the performance stops — your real opinions, your real struggles, what you find funny when you’re not worried about whether it’s the right thing to find funny. The Mirror isn’t more virtuous than the Mask. It’s just more real.”
- 4 **THE GAP · 8 MIN** Privately, your teen notes where the gap between their two sides is biggest. Then, without revealing contents: “What does maintaining that gap cost you — in energy, in connection? What would it take to close it by even 10% in one safe place?”

② The Autism Lens

- ◆ **Make It Literal & Concrete** Make it a literal **two-column audit** — Mask on the left, Mirror on the right — not an open “who are you really?” For autistic teens, masking is often years-deep and conscious; naming it explicitly as a thing with a cost (not a moral failure) is the whole point. “The gap is where the cost lives” is a concrete, memorable rule.
- ◆ **Sensory Regulation — tied to this theme** This is the autism lesson in disguise: autistic masking is exhausting and, long-term, dangerous. **Frame home as the place the Mask comes off** — stimming, info-dumping about a special interest, dropping eye contact, are all the Mirror, and all welcome. Keep this low-demand and private; a teen who can’t even look at the Mirror column may fear what’s under there. Don’t push.
- ◆ **Universal Design for Communication** **Write, type, or keep it entirely in their head.** The audit is never collected or shared. “One word per column” is a complete answer. AAC and drawing count.

③ Elite Conversation Starters

CAR “Who do you have to **perform** being at school? Is it tiring keeping that up all day?”

AT HOME “This is a no-Mask zone. You don’t have to be ‘on’ with me — ever.”

MEALTIME Model: “There’s a version of me I perform at work that isn’t really me. Here’s the gap...”

PARENT SCRIPT — MODEL IT ON YOURSELF

“Honestly? There’s a polished, agreeable version of me I run at work all day — that’s my Mask. The real me is blunter and needs way more quiet. Keeping that gap wide is **exhausting**. Home is where I get to drop it. I want that to be true for you too.”

④ Printable Visual Assets & Charts

THE MASK VS. THE MIRROR

THE GAP BETWEEN THEM IS WHERE THE COST LIVES **THE MASK · WHAT I PERFORM** What I show others What I emphasize What I hide The version that's 'on' **THE MIRROR · WHAT'S REAL** My real opinions My actual struggles What I value Who I am when no one's watching

The Mask isn't the problem. **The gap between Mask and Mirror is where the cost lives.**

▲ SAFETY & ESCALATION

Not high-risk, but the audit occasionally surfaces something heavy for a teen carrying a big self-perception burden. Watch for a teen who can't tolerate even hearing the Mirror described, or who stares at a blank page — that can mean high fusion with the curated self, or fear of what's underneath. Don't address it publicly; note it, stay warm, and keep crisis numbers (988) visible.

♦ PARENT REFLECTION

Where is my teen's Mask-Mirror gap widest — and is home a place the Mask actually comes off? What did I learn about who they are under the performance?

END OF FREE PREVIEW

That was Lesson 1 of 4 units • 28 lessons.

The free preview ends here — you've just read the parent's letter, the orientation, the crisis & safety reference, and the first complete lesson, exactly as a family would use it at the kitchen table. The rest of the year continues in the same shape: one complete lesson per spread, in any order you like.

- ◆ Every lesson built from the same six parts — once you know one, you know them all.
- ◆ The Autism Lens on every lesson: Make It Literal, Sensory Regulation, and Universal Design for Communication.
- ◆ Elite conversation starters tagged to the real moments of a day — each with a script to model first.
- ◆ Printable anchor charts and home tools, plus a Safety & Escalation band and a Parent Reflection on every lesson.

Take it home.

The complete The Interior Home Edition — all 4 units • 28 lessons, undiluted — is available in the Store. A check-in, not an exam; a curriculum, not a worksheet.